

Balsam of Peru Diet



What is it?

Balsam of Peru (BOP) is a natural substance obtained from the bark of a tree found in Central America. It contains many substances that are known contact allergens, such as:

- Benzoic acid
- Cinnamates (Cinnamic acid, alcohol, or aldehyde)
- Eugenol
- Ferulic acid
- Coniferin
- Vanillin

People with allergic contact dermatitis can be so sensitive to their allergen that they must avoid skin exposure AND ingestion (eating) of the chemical. This type of allergy could cause dermatitis on the hands, face, around the mouth, or at the skin folds (armpits, groin). Some people may have dermatitis all over their bodies.

For some people allergic to Balsam of Peru, a diet low in the above substances can reduce the likelihood of skin reactions. A two-month trial of removing foods and beverages that contain BOP-related substances is recommended.

Low Balsam of Peru Cookbook:

- Savor without Sensitivity: Balsam of Peru Friendly Recipes by Karen Bruns

References

1. *Dermatitis* 2013;24:153-60.
2. *J Am Acad Dermatol* 2001;45:377-81.

What should I avoid as part of a low BOP diet?

- **Citrus fruit (and citrus-containing products):** such as citrus flavor, peel, zest, or oil—including orange, lemon, lime, grapefruit, bitter orange, tangerine, and Mandarin orange.
- **Tomato (and tomato-containing products):** such as ketchup, tomato sauce, Italian or Mexican red sauces, pizza, chili, ketchup, chili sauce, and barbecue sauce.
- **Vegetables:** Beets and asparagus
- **Sweet flavorings:** such as those found in pastries and other bakery goods, cakes, cookies, candy, chewing gum, chocolate, and ice cream.
- **Spices:** such as cinnamon, cloves, vanilla, curry, nutmeg, allspice, anise, cassia, mace, dill, bay leaves, basil, curry powder and ginger.
- **Colas:** soft drinks, such as Dr. Pepper, that may contain sweet flavorings and spices.
- **Liquors:** such as wine, beer, gin, whiskey, spiced liqueurs and vermouth.
- **Spicy Condiments:** chutney, pimento, and pickled items, including pickles.
- **Other:** perfumed tea and tobacco, wheat and rye.

In addition, the ACDS Contact Allergen Management Program® (CAMP®) can help manage contact dermatitis. It helps to find products that are safe to use by creating a list of products that do not contain one's allergens. For more information about CAMP®, please ask your doctor or visit www.contactderm.org.

REVISION DATE: NOVEMBER 2025

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